'he who ties the knot around the tiger's neck should also be the one to untie it' to define his expectations from India. The cat-and-mouse game with the Chinese continued throughout 1998. In October, National Security Advisor Brajesh Mishra made a pointed statement to the effect that India did not regard China as an enemy and had no intention of engaging in an arms race with it. [35]

Again, India showed to the rest of the international community that it was willing to address Chinese concerns and work with them. The Chinese remained unmoved and maintained their posture of no contact. Others, besides the Americans, also began talking to India. This included the British, the French and the Russians. China's policy led to its own self-isolation. An announcement on 7 November 1998 by the Clinton White House on the partial easing of sanctions on India and Pakistan, citing progress by India in declaring a moratorium on future testing and a public commitment to address US non-proliferation concerns, was a further blow to Chinese expectations that India would be punished by the international community until it yielded. Years later, Sha Zukang, who was regarded as China's point person on nuclear non-proliferation matters, would be bitter over the way in which the Americans and their allies had so quickly violated the common position taken by the P-5 in New York. He blamed the Americans for violating UN Security Council Resolution 1172 in pursuing nuclear cooperation with India. He felt that because of the bad example set by the US, its allies like France, Britain and Japan had followed suit. [36] In reality, the Chinese had themselves to blame. Sha Zukang and China had misread the Americans and misjudged India too.

By early 1999, the Chinese began to realize that the economic sanctions were not having the sort of devastating effect on the Indian economy that they had hoped for, and that it was, in